

IDEA

NAPOLEONIC CODE

The Civil Code, drawn up on Napoleon's orders between 1800 and 1804, is often regarded as his most enduring legacy. His personal influence upon the code favored patriarchal authority and "family values." At Napoleon's insistence, the code states: "The wife owes obedience to her husband." Men under 25 could not marry without their parents' consent. Although divorce was permitted, it was difficult to obtain. Napoleon's code broadly upheld the rights and freedom of conscience established by the French Revolution.



COPY OF
NAPOLEONIC CODE

the Revolution, at the age of 24, he survived their fall and relaunched his career by providing artillery to defend their successors, the Directorate, against an uprising in October 1795 (see right). France fought all the major European powers, either individually or in coalitions, between 1793 and 1815 (see pp.306–07). Once Napoleon was made head of the Army of Italy in March 1796, there was no looking back. Reviving a moribund force, he had a spectacular series of victories, including defeat of the Papal army, that made him a French hero.

Supreme power

Napoleon was not content with being recognized as a superb general. Only supreme political power could satisfy the scope of his grandiose ambition to create an empire. Brought in as the military muscle to back a political conspiracy against the Directorate in 1799, he effortlessly shifted into the leading role in government as First Consul, and from there to absolute imperial power in 1804. Napoleon was a hard-working, intelligent head of government who supervised the creation of a new legal, administrative, and educational system in France. He was, however, also a man inspired by a sense of destiny, who believed in his



Imperial insignia

In his imperial crest, Napoleon alludes to Emperor Charlemagne, his 9th-century predecessor (ivory hand of justice) and the Roman Empire (eagle).

Retreat from Moscow

As the French withdrew from Russia in 1812, Marshall Ney (center) inspired the rearguard of the Grande Armée to resist the Russian cossacks.



“Bonaparte’s whole life, civil, political and military, was a fraud.”

DUKE OF WELLINGTON, 1835

carefully nurtured public image as savior of France and successor to the Holy Roman Empire of Charlemagne (see pp.188–91).

Military genius

Napoleon genuinely desired peace—on his own terms—but spent almost the entirety of his years in power at war. He demonstrated his military genius time and again, maneuvering large-scale armies quickly to engage the enemy in decisive battle with maximum application of force. It was a style of warfare that often required his men to sustain heavy casualties in the pursuit of victory. Nevertheless, he was popular with the soldiers and

his presence on the battlefield always heartened them. He knew how to use titles and decorations—including the *Légion d’honneur*, which he instituted—to reward and inspire effort.

Downfall

Napoleon’s character undoubtedly had defects. He was often dishonest, lying in battlefield dispatches to aggrandize his own role. By the time he invaded Russia in 1812, his grasp of the realities of power had begun to waver. Overreaching was always likely to be his downfall. He was finally defeated at Waterloo in 1815 and imprisoned on St. Helena, an island in the Atlantic. To the last, he devoted himself to the

service of his self-image, writing his memoirs in captivity. He left a legend, but not the imperial dynasty that he had hoped to found.

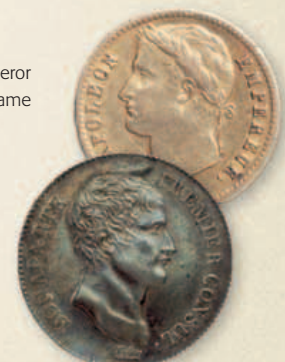
Deathbed scene

Horace Vernet depicted the dead Napoleon crowned with laurel leaves, as a Roman emperor would have been, and with Christ-like features. Napoleon’s admirers believed he was poisoned by the British, but he probably died of stomach cancer.



TIMELINE

- August 15, 1769** Born in Ajaccio, Corsica.
- 1779–84** Attends military school.
- September 1785** Commissioned as a sublieutenant in the artillery after a year at the Royal Military School in Paris.
- 1791–93** Elected a lieutenant-colonel in the Corsican National guard.
- June 1793** Flees from Corsica with his family.
- August 10, 1794** Briefly arrested because of his links with the Jacobins, a radical political group.
- October 5, 1795** Suppresses an attempted royalist coup in Paris. The Directorate gives him command of the Army of the Interior.
- March 9, 1796** Marries Josephine de Beauharnais.
- March 1796–April 1797** As commander of the Army of Italy, claims a series of victories over Austria, and Piedmont in Italy.
- May 1798–August 1799** Leads Army of the Orient to invade Egypt and Palestine.
- November 9, 1799** Back in France, he takes part in a coup that establishes a new government, the Consulate; the following month he becomes its leader (First Consul).
- June 14, 1800** Defeats the Austrians at Marengo in Italy.
- December 24, 1800** Survives an assassination attempt by royalists.
- August 2, 1802** Declared Consul for life.
- December 2, 1804** Crowns himself Emperor of France in Notre Dame Cathedral, Paris.
- December 2, 1805** Defeats the Austrian and Russian armies at Austerlitz.
- October 14, 1806** Defeats Prussia at the twin battles of Jena and Auerstadt.
- July 15, 1809** Marriage to Josephine annulled; marries the Austrian Archduchess Marie Louise in March the following year.
- March 20, 1811** His son is born, styled by Napoleon as the King of Rome.
- June 1812** Invades Russia, but retreats in October.
- October 16–19, 1813** Defeated at Leipzig by the forces of Prussia, Sweden, and Austria.
- April 6, 1814** Abdicates after Paris is occupied by the Allies (Prussia, Russia, and Austria); he is exiled to the Mediterranean island of Elba.
- March 20, 1815** Escapes from Elba and enters Paris.
- June 18, 1815** Defeated at Waterloo in Belgium by the British and Prussian armies.
- July 15, 1815** Surrenders to the British.
- May 5, 1821** Dies a prisoner on the island of St. Helena.



FRENCH CURRENCY BEARING
NAPOLEON’S IMAGE